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women in India's tech ecosystem has access to a mentor. That gap is not just unfortunate, it's costly. A 2023 McKinsey-Women in the Workplace report highlights that women who have sponsors are 27% more likely to ask for and receive promotions. This distinction matters, especially in tech, where women are often the only ones in the room: the only engineer, the only product lead, the only founder in a pitch meeting. For women in the "messy middle"—mid-career stages where the pipeline typically starts leaking—these relationships

can be the difference between exit and acceleration.

### ENTRY & ELEVATION

While women make up 34% of entry-level roles in India's tech sector (Nasscom Women in Tech Report, 2023), the number plummets to 13% at managerial levels, 7% at leadership levels, and just 8% in the C-suite. The pattern is clear: the higher the ladder, the fewer women there are. This isn't due to a lack of ambition or ability. A McKinsey Global Survey found that 58% of women aspire to senior leadership,

but systemic barriers erode that ambition over time. The reasons are layered: a lack of targeted upskilling opportunities, unconscious bias in evaluations and promotions, societal expectations surrounding caregiving and mobility, poor access to flexible work models, and the "invisible tax" of being the only woman in a room, meeting, or leadership pipeline. This broken pipeline must be addressed with a systems-level response. Governments must incentivise companies that demonstrate measurable gender diversity at senior levels through tax breaks, awards, or public rankings. Inclusion must be embedded into curriculum design, faculty representation, and R&D priorities. Representation in academia shapes what future generations believe is possible.

### SKILLING WOMEN

While women make up 36% of India's overall tech workforce, less than 12% are in AI and data science roles, and just 6% are in cybersecurity. To correct this, we need national-scale investment in next-gen skilling for women, backed by measurable outcomes. This means specialised skilling programmes in AI, cloud, cyber, green tech, and digital public infrastructure, designed specifically for women and delivered at scale through platforms like Skill India Digital, FutureSkills Prime, and Nasscom Women Wizards in Computing.

By 2047, India will have the largest pool of working-age talent in the world, over 1 billion people under the age of 60. To have a developed, digitally empowered, and inclusive India, we must ensure that this workforce is not only future-ready but equitably led. **BT**

*Views are personal*